

ROYALTIES 101 | A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR SOUTH AFRICAN & AFRICAN ARTISTS

Know what you are owed. Know who collects it. Know how to register.

Royalties are the ongoing income generated when your music is used — streamed, broadcast, performed, reproduced, or licensed. Many South African artists leave significant money uncollected every year simply because they have not registered with the right organisations or do not know which type of royalty applies to their situation.

This guide breaks down every major royalty type — what triggers it, who earns it, which South African organisations collect it, and what the picture looks like across major African markets. Royalty laws and collection structures differ by country, so always seek the advice of a qualified music lawyer or industry professional for specific guidance.

WHO IS ENTITLED TO ROYALTIES?

RIGHTS HOLDER TYPE	WHAT THEY OWN	ROYALTIES THEY EARN
Songwriter / Composer / Lyricist	The composition — melody, lyrics, and musical structure	Public performance royalties, mechanical royalties, sync fees, YouTube Content ID (composition share)
Music Publisher	Administers the composition on behalf of the songwriter	Publisher's share of public performance, mechanical, and sync royalties
Recording Artist / Performer	Their specific recorded performance on a sound recording	Neighbouring rights royalties, streaming income (via label or distributor), sync income (master side)
Session Musician / Background Performer	Their performance on a specific recording	Neighbouring rights royalties (via SAMPRA / AIRCO)
Record Label / Master Owner	The sound recording (master) itself	Master licensing fees, streaming income, sync fees (master side), neighbouring rights (maker share)
Music Producer	May own a share of the sound recording or have a defined royalty entitlement	Producer royalty (negotiated per deal), potentially neighbouring rights if registered as a maker

WHO PAYS? — MUSIC USERS IN SOUTH AFRICA & AFRICA

By law, any business or platform that uses music must pay for the right to do so. These music users pay royalty collecting organisations, who then distribute the money to rights holders. If you are not registered, you cannot receive your share — even if your music is actively being used.

BROADCAST	DIGITAL PLATFORMS	PUBLIC VENUES & BUSINESSES
SABC, e.tv, DStv, M-Net, community radio stations, campus radio, satellite radio, online radio	Spotify, Apple Music, Boomplay, Audiomack, YouTube, TIDAL, Deezer, Mdundo, Amazon Music, and 2,000+ others	Restaurants, bars, clubs, gyms, malls, hotels, airlines, casinos, cinemas, sports venues, retail stores

THE 5 TYPES OF ROYALTIES — EXPLAINED FOR SA & AFRICA

1. Public Performance Royalties

What it is	Generated whenever a composition is performed or broadcast publicly — on radio, television, in a restaurant, at an airport, in a retail store, at a live concert, or streamed online. This covers the composition (the song itself), not the recording.
Who earns it	Songwriters, composers, lyricists, and music publishers who own a share of the composition.
Collect in SA via	SAMRO (South African Music Rights Organisation) — samro.org.za . Register your compositions and membership is free. SAMRO distributes quarterly. Allow 3–10 months from first broadcast to first payment. For international use, SAMRO partners with affiliated PROs worldwide.
African Market Note	Nigeria: MCSN (Musical Copyright Society Nigeria) — mcsnnigeria.org . Kenya: MCSK (Music Copyright Society of Kenya) — mcsk.net . Ghana: GHAMRO (Ghana Music Rights Organisation) — ghamro.org . Tanzania: COSOTA (Copyright Society of Tanzania) — cosota.go.tz . Uganda: UPRS (Uganda Performing Rights Society) — uprske.org . Most African PROs are free to join and operate on a quarterly or bi-annual distribution cycle.

2. Neighbouring Rights Royalties

What it is	Neighbouring rights are separate from compositional royalties and are paid to the people who made the recording — not the people who wrote the song. They are triggered when a sound recording is broadcast or played publicly. In South Africa, this includes radio airplay and digital streaming.
Who earns it	Recording artists (featured and session performers), background vocalists, instrumentalists, and record labels or makers who own the sound recording.
Collect in SA via	SAMPRA (South African Music Performance Rights Association) — sampra.co.za . Register as a performer. AIRCO (African Independent Rights Collection Organisation) handles international neighbouring rights collection for African independent artists. Record labels or makers register directly with SAMPRA.
African Market Note	Neighbouring rights systems are still developing across much of Africa. Nigeria, Ghana, and Kenya have some framework in place but collection is inconsistent. If you are touring or getting airplay across Africa, register with AIRCO to maximise cross-border collection. RAAP (Ireland), PPL (UK), and SCPP (France) reciprocally collect in many African territories.

3. Mechanical (Reproduction) Royalties

What it is	Mechanical royalties are generated when a composition is reproduced — when your song is pressed onto a CD, made available for download, or streamed on a platform. The "mechanical" label is historical (from the era of player pianos and mechanical reproduction) but the principle applies equally to digital reproduction today.
Who earns it	Songwriters, composers, and music publishers who own the composition. This is separate from the recording — you earn mechanical royalties on your song even if someone else records a cover version.
Collect in SA via	CAPASSO (Composers, Authors and Publishers Association of South Africa) — capasso.co.za . Register your compositions with CAPASSO for mechanical rights collection. CAPASSO works alongside SAMRO on the publishing side. Independent artists without a publisher can collect both the writer and publisher share directly.
African Market Note	Mechanical collection agencies across Africa include MCSN (Nigeria), MCSK (Kenya), GHAMRO (Ghana), and COSOTA (Tanzania). Collection efficiency varies significantly by market. For international digital mechanical royalties, ensure your compositions are registered with CAPASSO so that BIEM (the international mechanical rights bureau) can collect on your behalf in foreign territories.

4. Digital Streaming & Performance Royalties

What it is	When your music is streamed on platforms such as Spotify, Apple Music, Boomplay, Audiomack, Deezer, TIDAL, or YouTube Music, multiple royalty streams are triggered simultaneously: a public performance royalty (for the composition), a mechanical royalty (for the composition), and a recording royalty (for the sound recording, paid via your distributor or label deal).
Who earns it	Songwriters and publishers (public performance + mechanical via SAMRO and CAPASSO). Recording artists and labels (recording royalty via distributor — DistroKid, TuneCore, Amuse, or direct label deal). Featured and session performers may also earn neighbouring rights if registered with SAMPRA.
Collect in SA via	SAMRO: public performance component. CAPASSO: mechanical component. Your digital distributor (DistroKid, TuneCore, Amuse, or similar): recording income from your sound recording. SAMPRA / AIRCO: neighbouring rights on broadcasts. These are four separate payment streams — all require separate registration.
African Market Note	Boomplay is the dominant music streaming platform in sub-Saharan Africa with over 100 million users. Audiomack has a strong foothold in Nigeria, Ghana, and East Africa. Mdundo focuses on East Africa. Register with all available platforms through your distributor and ensure your metadata (ISRC codes, artist name, composer credits) is accurate across every platform — errors cause payment delays and misdirected royalties.

5. Sync Licensing Fees

What it is	A synchronisation licence (sync licence) is a one-time or ongoing fee paid when your music is licensed for use alongside visual content — in a film, television show, advertisement, video game, online content, or documentary. Sync fees are negotiated directly (not collected via a PRO) and can range from a few thousand rands for a local ad to millions for a major international placement.
Who earns it	Both the composition owner (songwriter / publisher) and the sound recording owner (artist / label) must agree and be paid separately for any sync use. A single sync placement generates two fees: a master licence fee and a synchronisation licence fee.
Collect in SA via	There is no central collection body for sync — fees are negotiated between the music user (production company, ad agency, filmmaker) and the rights holders directly. A music lawyer, manager, or sync agent typically handles negotiations. Retain publishing rights wherever possible — buy-outs reduce your long-term earning potential.
African Market Note	South African film, television (SABC, e.tv, Showmax, Netflix Africa), and advertising industries are active sync licensors. Afrobeats, Amapiano, and other African genres are increasingly sought for international productions. Build relationships with music supervisors, post-production houses, and ad agencies. African streaming platforms (Showmax, Canal+) are commissioning increasing volumes of local content — creating new sync opportunities for SA artists.

REGISTER NOW — SOUTH AFRICAN ROYALTY COLLECTION BODIES

Each collecting organisation administers a different type of royalty. You may need to register with multiple bodies to collect everything you are entitled to. All registrations listed below are free for rights holders.

ORGANISATION	ROYALTY TYPE	WHO SHOULD REGISTER	WEBSITE
SAMRO	Public Performance	Songwriters, composers, lyricists, music publishers	samro.org.za
CAPASSO	Mechanical / Reproduction	Songwriters, composers, music publishers	capasso.co.za
SAMPRA	Neighbouring Rights (Performer)	Recording artists, session musicians, vocalists	sampra.co.za
SAMPRA	Neighbouring Rights (Maker)	Record labels, master owners, producers with maker rights	sampra.co.za
AIRCO	International Neighbouring Rights	SA performers seeking cross-border collection	airco.co.za
RISA (via NAB)	ISRC Code Registration	All recording artists — required for digital distribution	risa.org.za

ROYALTY COLLECTION BODIES ACROSS KEY AFRICAN MARKETS

COUNTRY	COLLECTION ORGANISATION	WEBSITE
Nigeria	MCSN — Musical Copyright Society Nigeria	mcsnnigeria.org
Kenya	MCSK — Music Copyright Society of Kenya	mcsk.net
Ghana	GHAMRO — Ghana Music Rights Organisation	ghamro.org
Tanzania	COSOTA — Copyright Society of Tanzania	cosota.go.tz
Uganda	UPRS — Uganda Performing Rights Society	uprske.org
Côte d'Ivoire	BURIDA — Bureau ivoirien du droit d'auteur	burida.ci
Senegal	BSDA — Bureau Sénégalais du Droit d'Auteur	bsd.sn
Cameroon	SOCILADRA	sociladra.cm
Pan-African (Streaming)	AIRCO — African Independent Rights Collection Organisation	airco.co.za

HOW LONG DOES IT TAKE TO RECEIVE ROYALTIES?

Royalty collection is not immediate. There is a deliberate delay between when your music is used and when you receive payment. Understanding these timelines prevents cash-flow surprises.

ROYALTY TYPE	SA COLLECTOR	TYPICAL DELAY	DISTRIBUTION SCHEDULE
Public Performance	SAMRO	3 – 10 months	Quarterly: February, May, August, November
Mechanical	CAPASSO	3 – 9 months	Quarterly (aligns with SAMRO distributions)
Neighbouring Rights	SAMPRA	6 – 18 months	Bi-annual or quarterly depending on collection type
Streaming Recording Income	Your distributor	Monthly (30–45 days after month-end)	Monthly — varies by distributor platform
Sync Licensing	Direct (no collector)	Negotiated — typically net 30 days from use	On invoice — no collection society involved

YOUR ROYALTY CHECKLIST — DO THIS TODAY

1. Register as a songwriter / composer with SAMRO — free, online, and takes under 30 minutes.
2. Register your compositions with CAPASSO — required to collect mechanical royalties from streaming and physical reproduction.
3. Register as a performer with SAMPRA — collect neighbouring rights on every broadcast of your recordings.
4. Get ISRC codes for every recording through RISA — these unique codes are your music's digital fingerprint and are required for distribution.
5. Get a UPC / EAN barcode for every release through GS1 South Africa — required for retail and catalogue identification.
6. Register your compositions on all major distributor/publisher admin platforms — ensure your writer credits and publisher splits are accurate.
7. Claim and verify your artist profiles on Spotify for Artists, Apple Music for Artists, and Boomplay for Artists — unclaimed profiles cannot receive full royalty data.
8. Ensure your distributor submits correct metadata: ISRC codes, composer names, publisher names, and split percentages for every track.
9. If operating outside SA, identify and register with the relevant PRO and neighbouring rights body in each market where your music is regularly played.
10. Review your royalty statements every quarter — errors do occur, and unclaimed royalties are redistributed if not claimed within the statutory period.

DISCLAIMER: This guide provides general information about royalty systems in South Africa and across African music markets as of 2026. Royalty laws, collection rates, and distribution timelines change regularly. This document does not constitute legal or financial advice. Always consult a qualified music lawyer, registered music industry professional, or the relevant collecting society for advice specific to your situation and territory.